

Moments of Truth

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Carlzon's high-stakes service encounters

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Moments of Truth are the brief, high-stakes interactions where a customer forms a decisive impression of a brand — points at which the relationship is won or lost in seconds.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Coined by Jan Carlzon, former CEO of Scandinavian Airlines, in his 1987 book of the same name; later extended by Procter & Gamble and Google's 'Zero Moment of Truth'.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Carlzon used the idea to refocus a struggling airline on the frontline encounters that customers actually remember, rather than internal process.

FIGURE 1 · MOMENTS OF TRUTH



Figure 1. A schematic of the Moments of Truth as applied in BARBM312 (illustrative).

HOW IT IS USED

The journey is scanned for the handful of interactions that disproportionately shape perception; resources and AI assistance are concentrated there.

WHEN IT IS USED

When prioritising limited CX investment, designing service recovery, and deciding where automation helps versus harms.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Service leaders, CX designers and frontline managers.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

It directs attention away from uniform investment across all touchpoints toward the decisive few — a sharp prioritisation lens for AI-enabled service.

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Engagement Flywheel · Slibrary 2

Personalisation Ladder · Slibrary 2

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SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Carlzon, J. (1987) Moments of Truth. Cambridge: Ballinger.

Lecinski, J. (2011) Winning the Zero Moment of Truth. Google.